

PRIVATE COUNSEL

The Client Experience

A Year in the Life with Don Phin, Esq.



Welcome

If you're reading this, one of two things has happened.

Either you've already decided we'd like to spend the next year together...

...or you're considering whether this is the right journey for you.

Either way, welcome.

Before we begin, I'd like to make one thing clear.

This isn't coaching.

It isn't consulting.

It isn't therapy.

And it certainly isn't about me having the answers to your life.

It's about creating one place in your world where you don't have to perform.

One place where you can remove the title.

The company.

The expectations.

The armor.

And simply be yourself.

For over forty years, I've had the privilege of sitting with CEOs, entrepreneurs, physicians, attorneys, family business owners, and men who've built extraordinary lives.

I've discovered something remarkable.

The bigger the success...

The fewer people there are with whom they can speak honestly.

Everyone wants something.

An investment.

A decision.

A favor.

Approval.

Access.

Very few simply want to understand them.

That's why Private Counsel exists.

Why Private Counsel Exists

By now you've assembled an impressive team.

A financial advisor.

An accountant.

An attorney.

An estate planner.

Investment managers.

Doctors.

Business advisors.

Each is excellent at helping you manage one part of your life.

But who helps you think about your whole life?

Who helps you decide whether selling the company is really about money...

...or identity?

Who helps you think through the conversation you've avoided with your daughter for three years?

Who helps you determine whether you're burned out...

...or simply living someone else's definition of success?

Who asks the questions no one else asks?

And helps you make these critical decisions.

That's my role.

Not to replace your advisors.

To connect what they cannot.

Because life isn't lived on a spreadsheet.

Before We Begin

I have no interest in solving the wrong problem.
Most people are diagnosed long before they're understood.
The business isn't always the issue.
The marriage isn't always the issue.
The health isn't always the issue.
They're often symptoms.
Before we discuss solutions...
I want to understand your life.
We'll spend time talking.
Walking.
Sharing meals.
Sometimes saying very little.
I'll ask questions you've probably never been asked.
Questions that don't fit neatly into a spreadsheet.
Not because I need information.
Because understanding always comes before wisdom.
Diagnosis always comes before prescription.



Three Lives

I've come to believe every successful person lives three lives.

The first is your public life. The one everyone knows.

The biography.

The accomplishments.

The wealth.

The titles.

The applause.

It's the version people admire.

Sometimes resent.

The second is your private life.

Your spouse.

Your children.

Your closest friends.

The people who know when you're tired.

Who've seen your disappointments.

Who know your strengths and your blind spots.

Then there's a third life.

Your secret life.

Not secret because it's shameful.

Secret because almost no one has access to it.

The fears you never say out loud.

The guilt, regret, and remorse.

The dreams you've postponed.

The questions that wake you up at three in the morning.

The strange thing about success is that it often enlarges all three lives while making them harder to integrate.

Private Counsel is where those three lives finally meet.

Everything you bring into that space stays there. Not because a contract says so. Because trust that deep only works if it's absolute.

There Is No Curriculum

One of the first questions clients ask is,

"So, what's the program?"

I've learned you can have a process to help frame the journey. We will dive into purpose, relationships, health, and spirit. Those things that tend to end up in the rear-view mirror while we are building the wealth. But...

Life already has it's agenda.

We will co-create a unique experience that includes monthly meetings, three retreats, and as-needed calls.

If your company receives an acquisition offer...

that's our agenda.

Or, you've already sold your company, and you're really trying to figure out what comes next...

that's our agenda

If your wife says she's unhappy...

that's our agenda.

If your father is dying...

that's our agenda.

If you're toasted and out of shape...

that's our agenda.

If you're lost...

we'll begin there.

I don't have an agenda for you. We are not making sausage. Your second climb journey is uniquely yours.

It is designed with you in mind, and I'm here to facilitate it.

Council Days

About once each month, we spend an entire day together.

Depending on schedules and locations, those days will be both in person and online.

No rushing.

No watching the clock.

No squeezing your life between conference calls.

Sometimes we'll begin with coffee overlooking the ocean.

Sometimes with a walk through the woods.

Sometimes sitting quietly before either of us says a word.

Sometimes a few shorter Zoom meetings that month.

I've learned that people often don't need better answers.

They need better questions.

And enough space to answer them honestly.

Some conversations last five minutes.

Others continue all day.

Sometimes we solve an important decision before lunch.

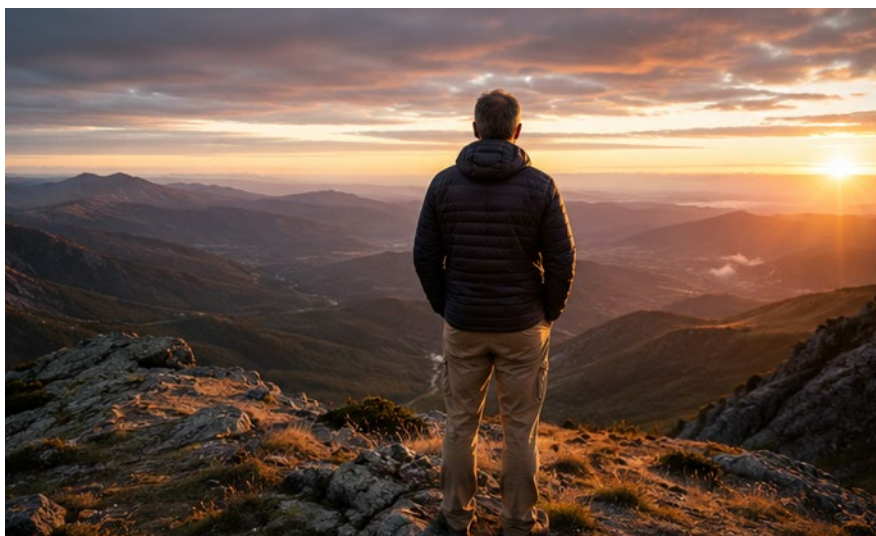
Sometimes we never discuss decisions at all.

Sometimes we laugh.

Sometimes we sit quietly because silence is doing better work than either of us could.

Every Council Day is different.

Every one should leave you lighter than when you arrived.



The Retreats

Three times a year, we leave normal life behind for a few days.

Not to escape it.

To see it more clearly.

Each retreat has its own purpose.

The first is Discovery.

Mostly walking. Mostly talking. A hiking retreat, built to get to know each other through shared effort rather than a conference table.

The second is Deep Immersion.

Somewhere built for long, unhurried conversation in a resort-type environment. This is where we go into the weeds — fears, concerns, aspirations, judgment, regret. Whatever is actually there.

The third is Wrap-Up.

A quieter setting — yoga, meditation, a place built for stillness. We look back at the year, and we build the plan for what comes next.

Between retreats, there are invitations — a book, a film, a scavenger hunt, and an experience to try alone or together. Never assignments. Just other ways to keep discovering yourself between the sit-down conversations.

The destination is never the point.

Perspective is.

Distance has a way of shrinking problems that once felt enormous.

Walking side by side often produces conversations that never happen across a conference table.

Some retreats can include your spouse.

Some don't.

Sometimes we'll spend hours discussing one decision.

Other times we'll never mention business.

Life decides, not some formula.

The Phone Rings

The relationship isn't measured by scheduled meetings.

It's measured by the unexpected ones.

The phone rings.

"Don..."

"I have to make a decision and need another perspective."

Sometimes that's all that's said.

Over the years those conversations have included...

"My board wants me to sell."

"My venture capital partners are pushing too hard."

"I think my COO is lying."

"My son wants into the business."

"My daughter wants nothing to do with it."

"My marriage is hanging by a thread."

"I've just been diagnosed."

"I don't know who else to talk to."

Those conversations are why Private Counsel exists.

Not because I have all the answers.

Because no one should make life's biggest decisions alone.

Living "In the Making"

One idea quietly changes almost every client.

Most people postpone becoming.

"When I retire... Then I'll..."

"When I sell the business... Then I'll..."

"When I have more time... Then I'll..."

"When the kids are older... Then I'll..."

I call it the *When... and Then Game*.

But life keeps moving.

Private Counsel invites a different way of living.

The *In the Making Game*.

"I'm a healthy person, in the making."

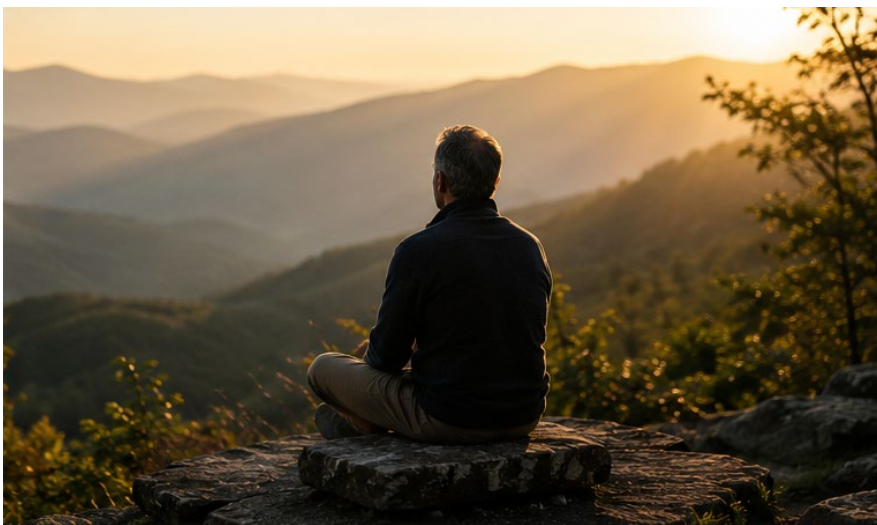
"I'm a better husband and parent, in the making."

"I'm someone discovering my purpose, in the making."

When you are in the making, you stop living in the future.

You begin living now. In the present. It's who you are, not who you will become.

This year will be a journey where you are in the making!



Looking Honestly

Charles Dickens understood transformation better than many psychologists.

Scrooge wasn't changed because someone lectured him.

He changed because he finally saw his life.

His past.

His present.

His future.

Without illusion.

Throughout our work together we'll occasionally do the same.

We'll look honestly at guilt.

Regret.

Remorse.

Not to punish you.

To free you.

The goal is never shame.

The goal is awareness.

Awareness creates choice.

Choice creates freedom.

And on the other side of that freedom is the thing you were after all along.

Connection.

Purpose.

Peace.

Invitations

I don't give homework.

Homework feels like school.

This isn't school.

Instead, I'll occasionally extend an invitation.

To write a letter you'll never send.

Take your granddaughter somewhere she'll always remember.

Volunteer where no one knows your accomplishments.

Leave your phone behind for an afternoon.

Have the conversation you've postponed for years.

Sit quietly beside the ocean.

Watch the sunrise.

Create something with your hands.

Forgive someone.

Ask forgiveness.

Journal after a difficult day.

These aren't assignments.

They're opportunities to experience yourself differently.

One Year Later

Imagine we've spent a year together.

Your life probably won't look dramatically different from the outside.

You may still own the same company...or not.

Live in the same house.

Have the same family.

Know many of the same people.

But inside...

Everything feels different.

You're sleeping better.

You're healthier.

You've had the conversations you've avoided.

Your marriage is stronger.

Or, you've ended it honestly.

You've repaired relationships that mattered.

You've accepted those that couldn't be repaired.

You make decisions with greater confidence.

Not because you're certain.

Because you're clear.

You're no longer measuring your life solely by what you've accumulated.

You're measuring it by how fully you're living it.

By the peace you feel when your head finally hits the pillow.

By how deeply you're loving, and being loved.

A Final Thought

One day your company will belong to someone else, if doesn't already.

The titles will pass.

The applause will fade.

The wealth will eventually be distributed.

What remains...

Are the conversations you had.

The people you loved.

Loved you received.

The courage you showed.

The forgiveness you extended.

The legacy you created.

If our year together helps you live that life more intentionally...

Then it will have been one of the best investments either of us ever made.

This is your invitation to come on that journey with me!

— *Don Phin. Esq.*



donphin.com/private